

As the war wound down, however, the steady stream of goods onto the islands slowed to a trickle, and eventually came to an end. The airplanes stopped coming, the military bases and airstrips closed, and all the foreigners withdrew. The once spectacular flow of goods and material wealth had ceased completely. The islanders were left as they had been before.

The islanders were perplexed by the sudden change in their fortunes. What had happened to the great flow of wealth and material well-being they had enjoyed for so many years? What accounted for this unwelcome change that had occurred, and was there anything they could do to restore the material prosperity that had prevailed previously? The islanders were trying to make sense of their new world, and started identifying ways in which they might remedy their situation based on what they knew.

The Melanesian natives knew that things happen for a reason. They were not stupid. What was the nature of the connection between the foreigners, their actions, and the cargo? From the islanders' perspective, there appeared to be several possible explanations for what they had observed over time. For example, it seemed likely the foreigners were acquainted with certain methods of generating the great flow of wealth. The islanders had observed the foreigners do many different things, some of which perhaps were related to the arrival of the cargo in some way. What was the key?

The foreigners had come to the islands and built roads, bases, and airfields with towers overseeing illuminated landing strips, where airplanes filled with goods came to land, and were seen to accumulate. They conducted various marching drills, while holding weapons on their shoulders and wearing distinctive clothing. They hoisted ceremonial banners. The foreigners were very different, and did a lot of strange things.

The islanders reasoned that perhaps there was some sort of magic or deity involved in the process of wealth creation. Perhaps there was even some kind of connection to spirits or the natives' ancestors? Regardless, there appeared to be a clear connection between the foreigners and their various activities and the cargo. The natives reasoned that they were capable of doing everything they had seen the foreigners do. If some of the various rituals the islanders had observed could be recreated, these might very well activate the magical flow of materials to the island. And so they developed